NETHERBLOOM

Book of Remembrance



The Bride Who Stayed Below

The old grave-texts told the dead: do not drink from Lethe; find the spring of Memory. This Book is that spring.

THE SOUL OF THIS BOOK

The Bride Who Stayed Below

Almost saved, once.

They were married at noon in a meadow, under a sky without a single cloud, and he played for the wedding himself. Everyone said they had never heard music like it; the birds stopped to listen and the river went quiet in its bed. That same afternoon, running through the long grass with her shoes in her hand, she stepped on a snake. By evening she was among the dead.

He came after her. No living man had walked down into the dark and come back, but he played at the gates until the guards wept, and the queen of the dead was moved and said yes, on one condition. She could follow him up, all the way, if he did not look back at her before they reached the light. Not once.

So she followed his footsteps up through the dark without a word. He could not hear her; the dead make no sound on the stair. It was a long climb on the narrow stair between the dead and the living. She could see the grey of morning above them, and feel the warmth of his hand where it hung at his side, just ahead of her, almost close enough to touch. One step from the surface he turned to be sure she was there. She saw his face, the instant he turned to look at her: his joy, then his terror. Then the dark took her back.

She has stood in the shadows ever since, at the foot of that stair, deciding whether to remember his face or to let it go. She is not sure which would be kinder. The old ferryman would not take her; she was already halfway home once, he says, and the river does not carry anyone twice.



What the Ferrymen know

She knows the way back down better than anyone. The first time she would Linger in the dark, she is pulled one space back instead, as she was pulled back once before, and she keeps her memory. Turn her Soul card sideways when it has happened.

Twist: The first time she would Linger in the dark, she is pulled one space back instead of forgetting.

Key Memory: *his face, the instant he turned to look at me*



Keeping the Book

The Book has one page per Reach. Each page has four slots, **Place**, **Person**, **Deed** and **Feeling**, which fill a sentence about the soul's life.

You may **inscribe** a card when it Resonates, if its memory's slot is still empty on the current page. A **Key Memory** card may be inscribed whenever it is played face up. An inscribed card leaves the deck for good: you trade a useful card for a memory the soul will keep.

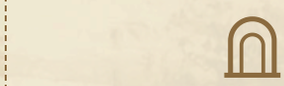
Chapter Blessing. When a page holds 3 memories (2 for the Garland Girl), the river grants the first of these that applies: mend a Fracture, drain Black Water, or return a forgotten card.

At the end, the Book is read aloud. Slots never filled read "...but this, the river has taken".

Tuck an inscribed card into the well for its slot: slide its four corners under the slits. Slide it out again to reuse the card next game.

I · Who I Was

I was born near...



PLACE

...but this, the river has taken

I loved...



PERSON

...but this, the river has taken

I once...



DEED

...but this, the river has taken

and ever since I have carried...



FEELING

...but this, the river has taken

☐ Chapter Blessing

Keepsakes ☐ ☐ ☐

II · What I Did

At...



PLACE

...but this, the river has taken

before...



PERSON

...but this, the river has taken

I...



DEED

...but this, the river has taken

The price was...



FEELING

...but this, the river has taken

III · What I Carry

I go now, leaving...



PLACE

...but this, the river has taken

forgiving...



PERSON

...but this, the river has taken

unable to undo the day I...



DEED

...but this, the river has taken

holding only...



FEELING

...but this, the river has taken

☐ Chapter Blessing

Keepsakes ☐ ☐ ☐

The Far Shore

At the Far Shore the Keeper lifts the veil and offers the cup. What the soul remembers decides how it drinks.

- ☐ **Inscribed in the Book**: kept and spoken. The soul crosses remembering what mattered most.
- ☐ **Forgotten**: lost to the river. The soul goes on, lighter and emptier, without it.
- ☐ **Never written** (still in the deck, a hand or the discard pile): never faced. Some things go across unsaid.

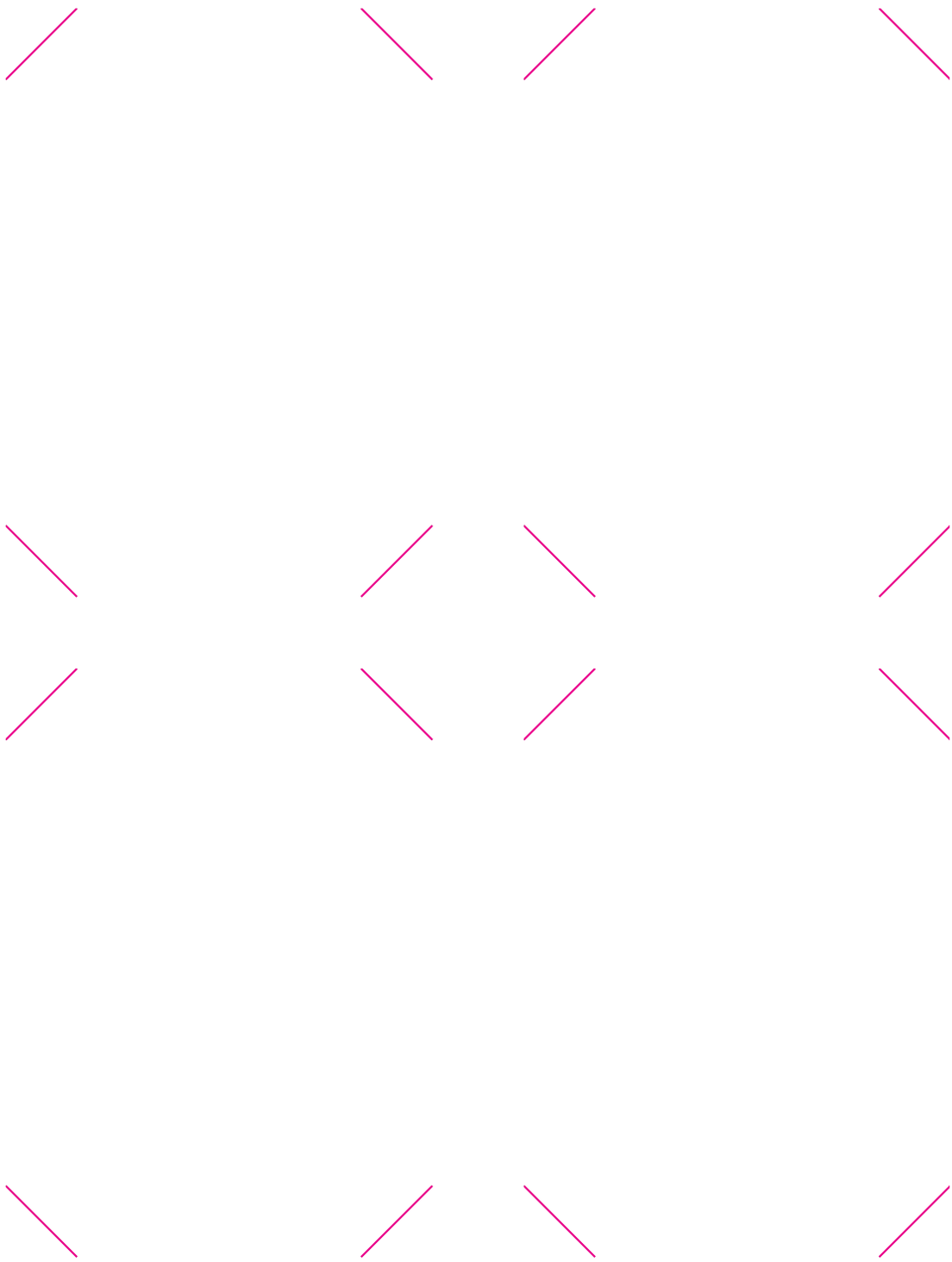
Then read the Book aloud, page by page. Even a lost crossing leaves a story: blanks read "...but this, the river has taken", and the epilogue tells how the soul was lost. Every game writes a different life.

FERRYMEN _____ LANTERN _____ DATE _____



NETHERBLOOM

RALPH LAUXIE



DIE LINE · pages 4–6 · photo-corner slits (magenta), 11 mm diagonals at each corner of the four 66 × 91 mm wells